CHAPTER 2

Beginnings

> Origins are a seductive necessity for historians.
> M. A. Asif

The epigraph above comes from M. A. Asif's recent book on the thirteenth-century text known as *Chach-nama*.[1] The text was the work of 'Ali Kufi, dated to AH 623/1226 CE and dedicated to Sultan Nasir al-Din Qabacha, ruler of Uchh and Multan in the southwestern Panjab AH 599–625/1203–1028 CE. *Chach-nama* and its patron have some bearing on our considerations here: they provide a preview of the historical arc of the Shansabanis, as they emerged from obscure beginnings in central Afghanistan and went on to create an extremely consequential imperial expanse. The select military entourage of the Shansabani sultan Mu'izz al-Din of Ghazna (r. AH 568–602/1173–1206 CE) included Qabacha, who had been a *ghulam* participating in the sultan's eastward campaigns to the Indus and ultimately to the north Indian plains during the late 1170s–1190s (cf. Chapters 1 and 5).[2] Mu'izz al-Din was assassinated near Lahore in AH 602/1206 CE; since he had no male progeny, his closest *ghulam*s were his heirs, and the "patrimony" of the sultan's conquests was divided among his favorites, including Qabacha.[3]

Asif's at times polemical position "against origins" or beginnings was, arguably, necessary to crack the proverbial nut that has been *Chach-nama* in the modern historiography on Islam in South Asia.[4] Certainly, Kufi's own avowal that his work was an early thirteenth-century Persian translation of a lost eighth-century Arabic original[5] already signaled the bifurcations between historical phenomena and their phenomenologies. Whether translation or new composition,[6] Kufi's *Chach-nama* was as much about the eighth-century integration of Islam into South Asia's cultural fabric, as it was about the historical consequences and intentional power of these events for its author and his audiences of the thirteenth century and beyond. And yet more than a millennium later, the obsessive scholarly and political pursuit of Islam's *beginnings* in South Asia – often amounting to nothing more than attestations of the Otherness of Islam and Muslims – has had dramatic and irreversible impacts on the lives of generations of people in this part of the world, and in South Asian diasporas elsewhere.[7]